

Flood Perceptions, Social Capital, and Public Support for Property Buyout Programs

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Motivation

What influences public support for a property buyout program?

- Climate change is likely to cause migration and retreat from vulnerable areas
- Expanding property buyout programs are one approach being considered by governments to manage migration
 - Flooding
- Few studies examine the views of the general public regarding buyout programs
 - Several studies about the views of program participants

Buyout Programs

- Federal Emergency Management Agency (FEMA)
 - Hazard Mitigation Grant Program (HMGP)
- Department of Housing and Urban Development (HUD)
- South Carolina Office of Resilience
 - Funding from HUD Community Development Block Grant-Mitigation (CDBG-MIT)
 - Voluntary
 - Residential properties in a floodplain



Public Support for Buyout Program

Push and Pull Factors

- Push
 - Flood risk ([Bendz, Göransson, and Van Well 2025](#); [Hotard and Ross 2025](#))
- Pull
 - Place attachment ([Mukherji et al. 2024](#); [Seebauer and Winkler 2020](#))
 - Social capital: bonding and bridging ([Binder et al. 2023](#))
 - Community attributes: resilience, infrastructure, location
- Individual
 - Political beliefs

Expectations

Flooding

H1a: *As concern about flooding increases, so does support for a property buyout program*

H1b: *Those who perceive flooding in their area to have increased will be more likely than others to support a property buyout program*

H1c: *Those who have experienced a flood will be more likely than others to support a property buyout program*

Expectations

Community Factors

H2a: *As perceptions of community resilience increase, support for a property buyout program decreases*

H2b: *As satisfaction with infrastructure increases, support for a property buyout program decreases*

H2c: *As bridging social capital increases, support for a property buyout program decreases*

H2d: *Those who live in a coastal county will be more supportive of a property buyout program than those in other areas*

Expectations

Individual Factors

H3a: *As bonding social capital increases, support for a property buyout program decreases*

H3b: *Homeowners are more likely than others to support a property buyout program*

H3c: *As time at current residence increases, support for a property buyout program decreases*

H3d: *As political conservatism increases, support for a property buyout program decreases*

Expectations

Homeowners Willingness to Accept

H4: *As the number of flood days increases, the likelihood of a stated willingness to accept a buyout increases*

Data and Analysis

Survey

- Residents of South Carolina
 - Recruited by *Cloud Research*
 - November - December 2023
 - $n = 470$
- Overall support
- Homeowners willingness to accept a buyout
 - Flood days treatment
 - Random draw from 7-200 days of disruptive flooding

Measures

Property Buyout: Support

Property buyouts are a policy for reducing risk to people and communities from severe storms, flooding, wildfires, and other extreme events. Buyouts also reduce costs to homeowners, insurance companies, and the government for rebuilding after events. In a buyout program, the government purchases private properties including homes and businesses that are damaged or at risk. Participating property owners must then relocate.

Measures

Property Buyout: Support

On a scale from 1 to 7, with 1 being strongly oppose and 7 being strongly support, please indicate your support for a property buyout program in South Carolina. In this program the federal government would purchase homes and businesses in South Carolina that have been damaged or at risk from natural disasters and the owners would need to move.

- **Average support = 4.17 on the 1 to 7 scale**

Measures

Property Buyout: Homeowners Willingness to Accept

Imagine that over the next few years, disruptive flooding events begin to occur in your community [7-200] days a year

With the above number of disruptive flooding days per year, how likely would you be to accept a property buyout of your home?

- **Average Willingness = 3.47 on the 1 to 5 scale**
- *58% somewhat or very likely to accept a buyout*

Measures

Flood Perceptions

- Concern over flooding in local area, *0 to 10 scale*
 - Average concern = 5.3
- Flooding has decreased (1), stayed the same (2), increased (3)
 - Average = 1.96
- Flood experience, *0 = never experienced a flood, 1 = experienced a flood*
 - 34% of respondents

Measures

Community Factors

- Bridging social capital, *1 to 5 scale*
 - Average = 2.47; Cronbach's $\alpha = 0.87$
- Satisfaction with community infrastructure (local government services, drinking water, roads, sewer), *1 to 5 scale*
 - Average satisfaction = 2.78; Cronbach's $\alpha = 0.69$
- Perceived community resilience and disaster response, *1 to 7 scale*
 - Average = 4.54; Cronbach's $\alpha = 0.89$
- Live in a coastal county, *0 = no, 1 = yes*
 - 27% of respondents

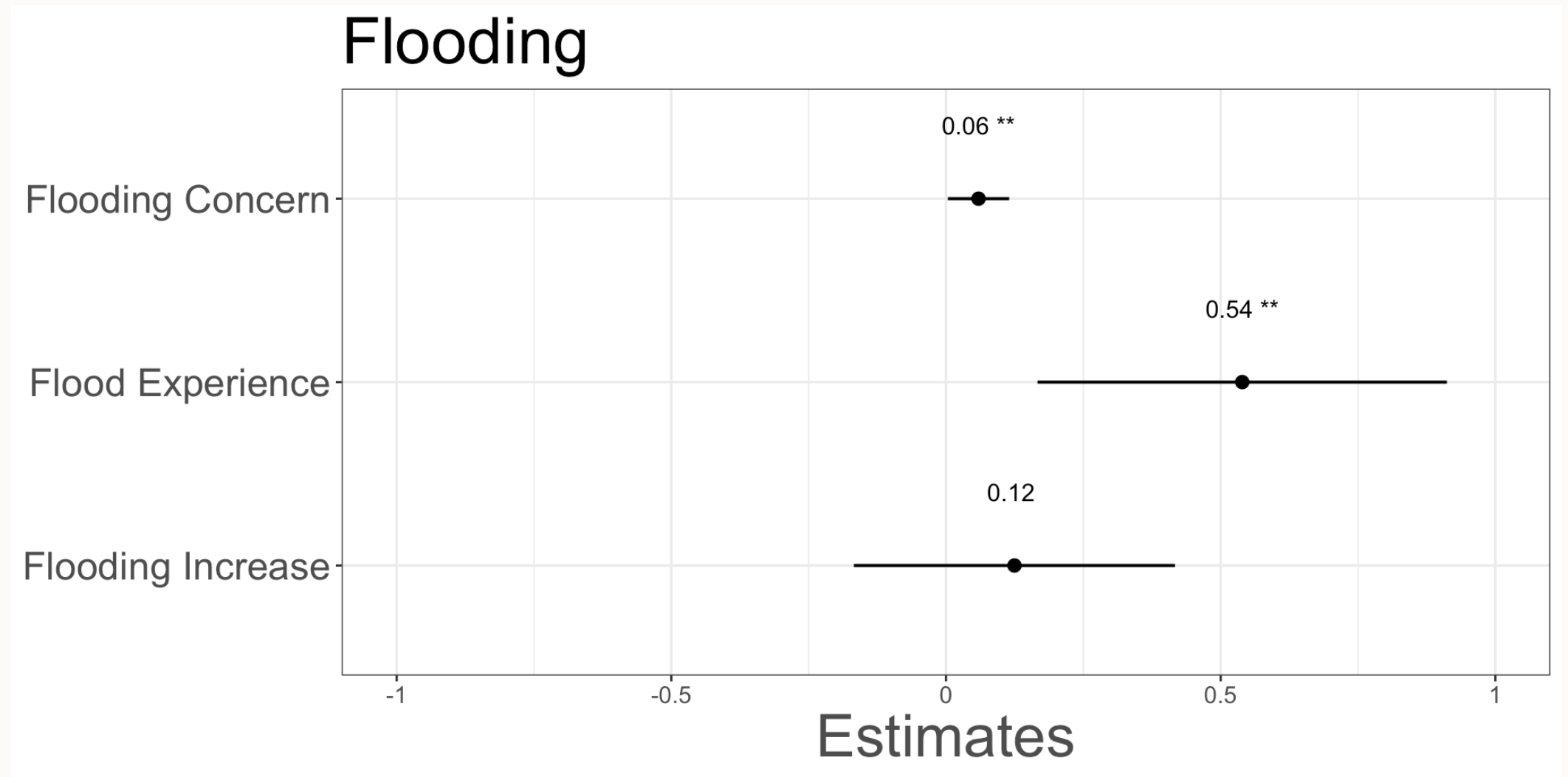
Measures

Individual Factors

- Bonding social capital, *1 to 5 scale*
 - Average = 2.59; Cronbach's $\alpha = 0.79$
- Political ideology, *1 (very liberal) to 7 (very conservative) scale*
 - Average = 4.2
- Homeowner, *0 = no, 1 = yes*
 - 60% of respondents
- Time at current residence, *1 to 4 scale*
 - Average = 2.75

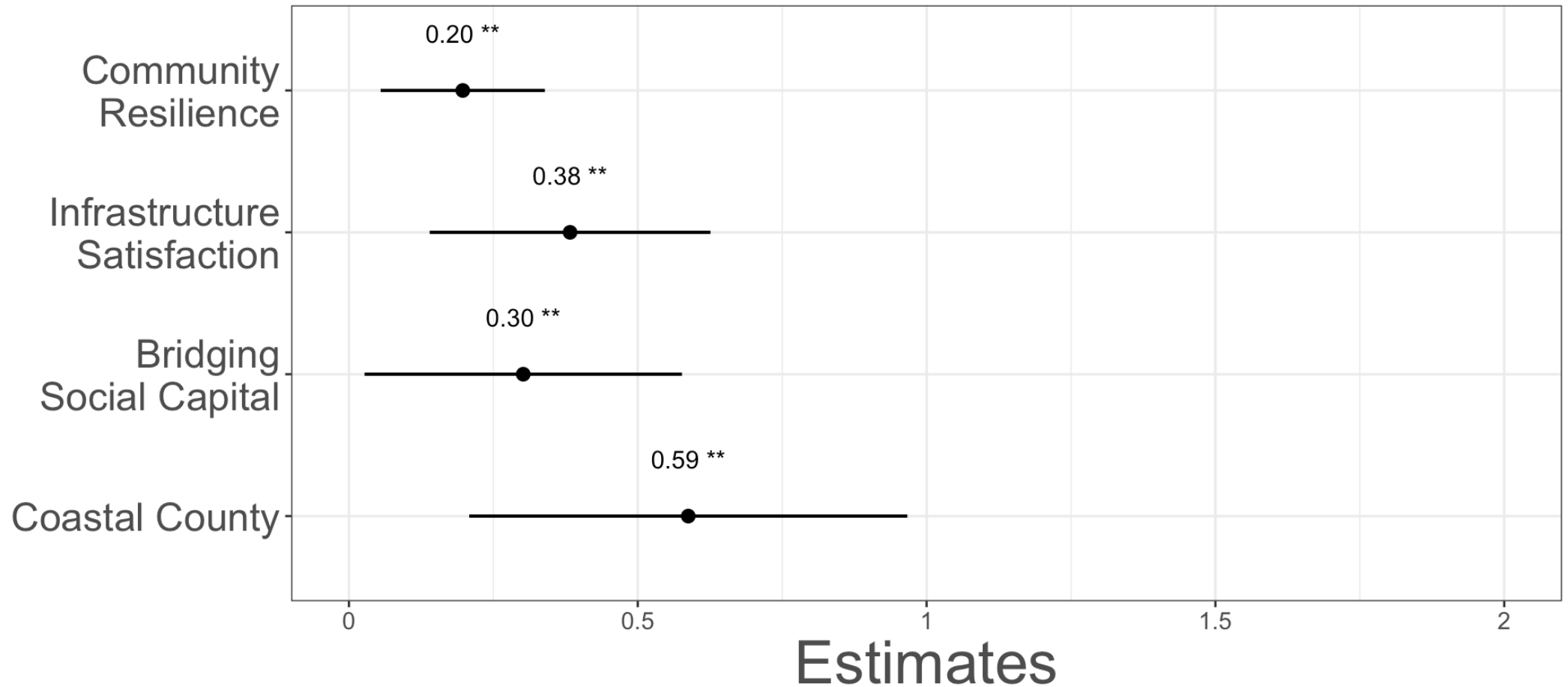
Results

Results

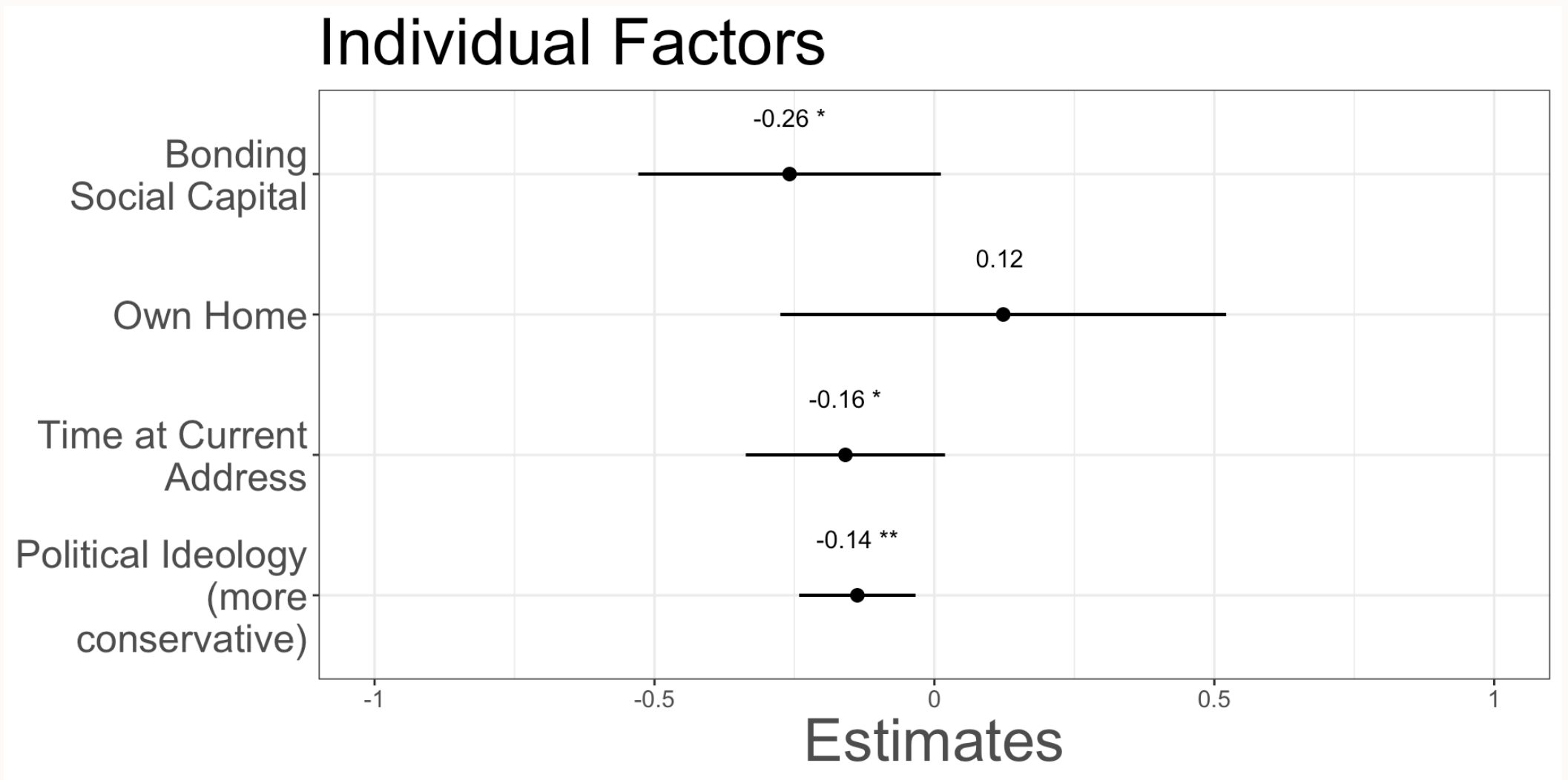


Results

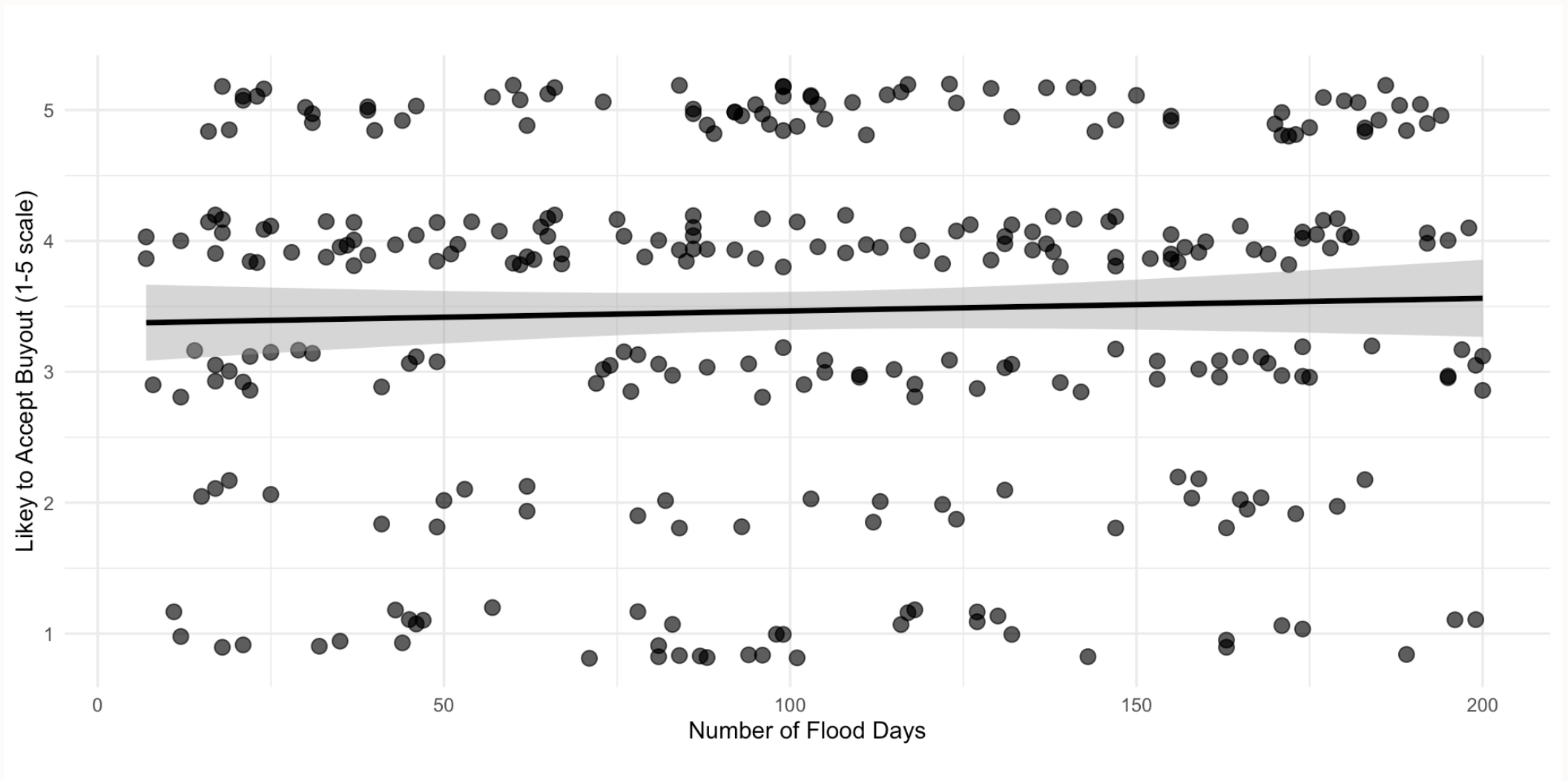
Community Factors



Results



Results: Flood Days and Accept Buyout



Discussion

- Flood risk (concern and experience)
- Individual factors
 - Increased bonding social capital, longer at current address, and more politically conservative associated with *decreased* support
- Community factors
 - *Increased community satisfaction (infrastructure, resilience, bridging social capital) associated with increased support*
 - Coastal county residents more supportive than others
- Homeowners
 - Number of flood days not associated with stated willingness to accept a buyout

Thank You!

References

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